



Grade 3 Social Studies

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADE 3 · FULL YEAR · THE YOUNG GEOGRAPHER-CITIZEN

160 min per week · 2 lessons weekly

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. More sources, maps, and activities are approved for this course than appear here, so scholars may see some variation in materials and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Grade 3 Social Studies forms the Young Geographer-Citizen. In the classical grammar stage, scholars observe, name, label, narrate, and describe: they master maps and globes, travel the continents and the regions of the United States, and meet the basics of economics, government, and citizenship. Recurring routines — Map Quest, Source Study, Timeline Thread, Council Chamber, and the Historian's Notebook — train the habits of careful observation, while the Virtue Lens connects what scholars study to Optima's seven pillars of virtue.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

- 1 Enter the World of Social Studies** (Weeks 1–3)
What historians, geographers, and citizens do; first notebook and source routines.
- 2 Age of Exploration** (Weeks 4–6)
Explorers, their routes, and reading sources and timelines about them.
- 3 Basics of Maps + Synthesis 1** (Weeks 7–11)
Map skills and tools, closing with The Cartographer's Review: a first synthesis built on map evidence.
- 4 Oceans, Continents, and Geographic Terms** (Weeks 12–14)
The physical vocabulary of the globe, with art and map work.
- 5 North America and the Caribbean** (Weeks 15–18)
Countries, regions, and peoples of our continent and its neighbors.
- 6 Regions of the United States + Synthesis 2** (Weeks 19–23)
The U.S. regions in depth, closing with The Regional Council, a council-style synthesis.
- 7 Basics of Economics** (Weeks 24–27)
Scarcity, goods and services, and choices, practiced through Trade and Choice decision work.
- 8 Government and Citizenship** (Weeks 28–31)
Civic principles, founding documents, and the habits of a good citizen.
- 9 Final Exhibition** (Weeks 32–33)
The Young Geographer-Citizen Exhibition: scholars present a claim using map, source, timeline, and virtue-lens evidence from the year.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Two social studies lessons each week.
- Lesson A, Enter the Story: background knowledge through readings, maps, images, sources, vocabulary, and guided observation.
- Lesson B, Work of the Historian-Citizen: map work, source analysis, timeline reasoning, council deliberation, or notebook synthesis.
- The Virtue Lens runs throughout, connecting study to honesty, courtesy, courage, service, perseverance, self-governance, and responsibility.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

TIME COMMITMENT

160 minutes / week

two lessons a week, about 80 minutes each

- Each week pairs one background lesson with one applied lesson.
- Synthesis weeks ask scholars to gather prior evidence and present a concise claim or exhibit.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A Historian's Notebook (any notebook) for observations, narrations, and evidence.
- Paper and colored pencils for map and timeline work.
- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, meeting twice a week on the school's weekly schedule.